



**CITY, UNITED WAY AND YMCA WORKING TOGETHER TO
SUPPORT BARTLETT CENTER CHILDCARE FAMILIES**

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FOR IMMEDIATE RELEASE**

The City of St. Joseph, United Way of Greater St. Joseph and YMCA of St. Joseph are issuing this joint statement regarding the future of the childcare operation at the Horace Mann Community Center and the families it serves. Following the Bartlett Center board's decision to dissolve the nonprofit on September 25, the three organizations are working together as next steps take shape, with the shared goal of developing a plan that supports a smooth transition and continuity of services for the families currently served by the program.

The City owns the Horace Mann Community Center, located at 409 S. 18th Street, where the Bartlett Center has operated a childcare center for the past several years. After the Bartlett Center announced that its board intended to vote on dissolution, the City reached out to United Way and the YMCA to explore options for a transition that would minimize disruption for families. The Bartlett Center board subsequently approved the dissolution.

As part of the transition planning, the YMCA of St. Joseph, in coordination with the City and United Way, is developing a plan to operate the childcare program for a 120-day transition period while longer-term plans for the facility and the services it may provide are evaluated. The YMCA is an established provider of childcare services in the St. Joseph community and brings a willingness to assist, along with experience and expertise to the transition effort.

The 120-day plan is currently being developed and remains tentative as the partners work to put an operational plan in place within a short timeframe. The immediate priority is to establish a

workable transition that allows families to continue accessing childcare services with as little disruption as possible.

“Our priority is the well-being of local children and families,” said Tammy Killin, CEO of the YMCA of St. Joseph. “The YMCA of St. Joseph is prepared to work collaboratively with current Bartlett Center staff and community partners to help maintain reliable childcare services at the Horace Mann Community Center.”

The partners also recognize that the future of the Horace Mann Community Center should be shaped by the needs of the broader community. As the transition moves forward, the plan is to convene a stakeholder group of residents and organizations to assess community needs and consider potential future uses for the facility. Those uses could include childcare, as well as other services or programs identified through the community assessment process.

Following that process, the City intends to issue a request for proposals (RFP) seeking a future tenant or tenants for the facility. Proposals received through that process would be evaluated with input from the stakeholder group to help determine an appropriate long-term plan for Horace Mann Community Center.

At this time, it would be premature to speculate on who may ultimately operate at the facility or what the long-term use of the building will be. The immediate effort is focused on supporting families and establishing a stable transition, while the longer-term planning process will provide an opportunity to evaluate the needs of the community and the best use of the facility.

The City, United Way and YMCA share a commitment to supporting the families who have been served by the Bartlett Center and to identifying and providing the services most needed by the wider St. Joseph community.

Additional information regarding the childcare transition and operational details will be shared as the plans are finalized.